Problem Gambling in Context: Psychological Traits and Structural Stressors Jointly Predict Gambling Severity

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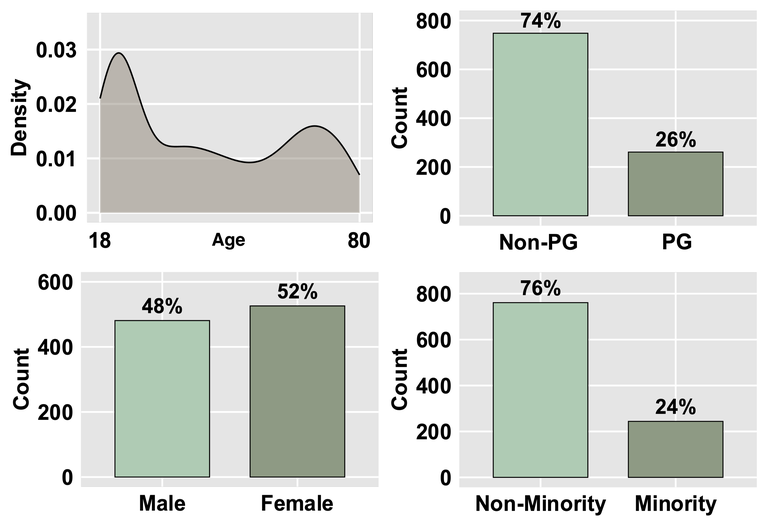
1. Introduction

• Although numerous studies have identified demographic, psychological, and environmental correlates of problem gambling, few have examined how these factors interact to influence gambling severity and urges.

• The effects of reward sensitivity may be amplified by co-occurring mental health symptoms and by exposure to structural stressors such as income inequality.

To address these gaps, we tested whether trait reward sensitivity, affective symptoms, and structural factors like income inequality interact to predict gambling severity and urges across a diverse national sample.

2. Sample Description



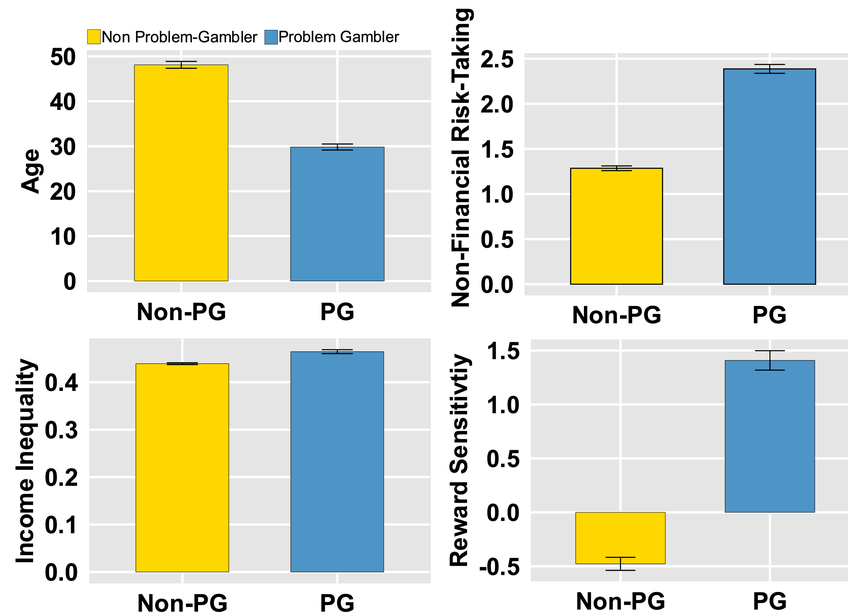
A **national survey** was collected from 1,031 individuals in the US via Qualtrics. Respondents ranged from 18 to 80 years old.

3. Methods

- The **brief biosocial gambling screen** was used to measure **problem gambling** (BBGS; Gebaur et al., 2010).
- **Trait reward sensitivity** was computed by the **Sensitivity to Reward subscale** (Conner, 2018) and **Behavioral Activation Subscale** (BAS) of BISBAS (Carver & White, 1994).
- **Mental health outcomes** were measured using the **7U7D Inventory** (Youngstrom et al., 2015) and the **UCLA Loneliness Scale** (Russel, 1996). **Income inequality** was measured by the **Gini coefficient.**

4. Characterizing Problem Gamblers

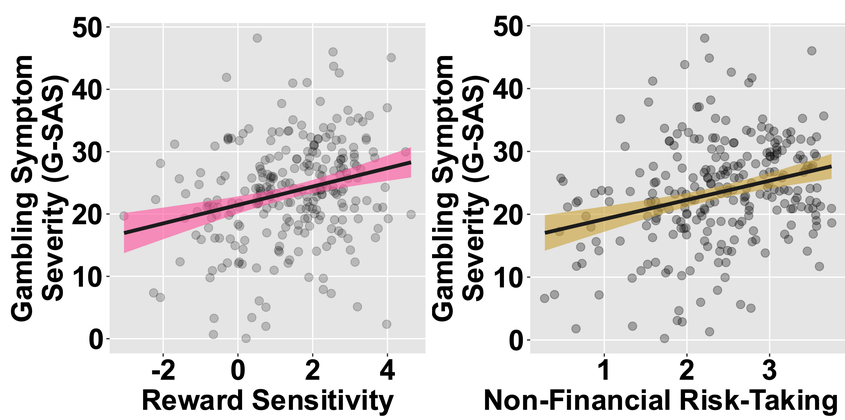
We first identified group differences between problem gamblers (PG) and non-problem individuals (Non-PG).



Significant differences in **age, non-financial risk-taking, income inequality, and reward sensitivity** were observed between groups. This suggests **individual, environmental, and group-level effects on problem gambling behaviors.**

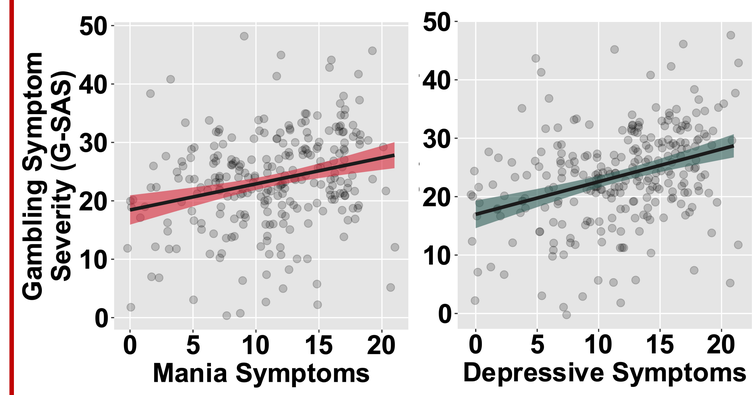
5. Reward Sensitivity and Risk-Taking in Problem Gamblers' Symptom Severity

All subsequent analyses focused on problem gamblers. We explored the relationship between gambling symptom severity, reward sensitivity, and non-financial risk taking.



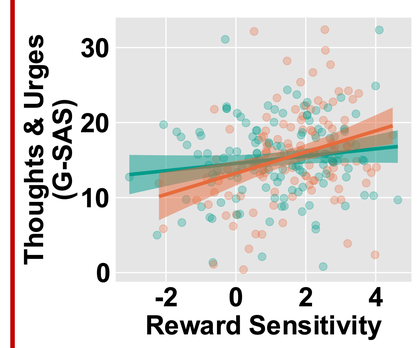
Results were significant at the $\alpha = .05$ level. **Reward sensitivity and non-financial risk-taking** were significant predictors of **gambling symptom severity.**

6. Symptom Severity Associated with Adverse Outcomes



Symptom severity significantly predicted both mania and depression symptoms, such that **symptoms of mania and depression increased with gambling symptom severity.**

7. Subjective Loneliness Moderates Reward Sensitivity and Gambling Thoughts and Urges



Loneliness moderated the association between **gambling thoughts & urges** and reward sensitivity, such that higher loneliness increased gambling thoughts and urges.

8. Conclusions and Future Directions

- Group **demographic, environment, and behavioral** differences existed between **problem gamblers and non problem gamblers.**
- Within **problem gamblers**, non-financial risk-taking, reward sensitivity, and symptoms of mania and depression were associated with increased **gambling symptom severity.**
- These results help to clarify the **changing demographic of problem gamblers**, and the **adverse effects of gambling symptoms**.